Jijeebisha Bhattarai

bhattaj@wfu.edu • jijeebishabhattarai.com

Current Position

Wake Forest University — **Winston-Salem, NC**
Visiting Assistant Professor, Department of Economics — *2026–*

Education

Binghamton University — **Binghamton, NY**
PhD, Economics — *2021–2026*
Dissertation: *Essays on Gender, Health, and Inequality*
Committee: Ajinkya Keskar (chair), David Slichter, Sulagna Mookerjee

Ramapo College of New Jersey — **Mahwah, NJ**
BS, Business Administration and Finance — *2016–2020*

Research and Teaching Interests:
Economics of Gender; Development Economics; Labor Economics; Applied Microeconomics

Research

Working Papers

- *When Rights Become Access: Abortion Reform and Missing Girls in Nepal* (with Ajinkya Keskar). *Under review.*

  Abstract: Reforms that expand reproductive rights change behavior only when they change effective access. We study Nepal, which legalized abortion in 2002 to reduce unsafe procedures, and ask when and where legal access affected the sex composition of births in a society with son preference. We combine quasi-random variation in firstborn sex with the staged rollout of abortion services and predetermined connectivity to city services in a triple-difference design. The rollout separates two margins. During the initial first-trimester rollout, later-birth hazards declined where services were reachable, but the male- and female-birth responses were not statistically distinguishable, and the sex composition of births did not change. Once access expanded to include second-trimester services, medication abortion, and midlevel providers, the annual probability of a female birth fell while male births did not decline. Nationally, the probability of a female birth fell by 0.49 percentage points, and the female share of later births in firstborn-girl families fell by 2.83 percentage points. The responses were concentrated within two hours of a city. Within this radius, the female birth probability and the female share declined by 1.30 and 6.52 percentage points, respectively. Back-of-the-envelope calculation maps the national composition estimate to an annual flow equivalent of about 11,900 missing girls at birth, or 1.91 percent of all births.

- *Hidden Gender Gaps in Child Poverty* (with Rossella Calvi and Ajinkya Keskar). *Under review.*

  Abstract: While son preference in India is well documented, measuring gender differences in children's consumption remains challenging because consumption is typically observed only at the household level. We estimate gender-specific child consumption using a collective household model and data from rural India. We find substantial within-household inequality: boys consume systematically more household resources than girls. Translating these allocations into individual-level poverty, roughly 63.6 percent of girls are poor, compared to 48.4 percent of boys. These gaps account for age- and sex-specific needs, persist across most of childhood, and are largely invisible to standard household-level poverty

measures. We further show that son-biased fertility stopping behavior contributes to the gender gap in child poverty by increasing girls' exposure to larger families with fewer resources per child, explaining less than 10 percent of the overall gap. Finally, combining our model-based poverty estimates with administrative mortality data, we show that hidden gender gaps in child poverty can account for one in three Indian missing girls.

- *Is the Mortality Gap Between Red and Blue States Caused by Government?* (with David Slichter and Case Tatro)

  Abstract: In the US, age-adjusted mortality rates are higher in "red" states, i.e., states with high support for the Republican Party. We ask whether this is attributable to state-level policies as opposed to confounding variables such as culture. Using a variety of empirical approaches, we find that state government explains between 0 and 20% of the mortality gap. Scaling this by the size of the (large) gap, red state policies increase mortality risk by 0–3% relative to blue state policies.

Work in Progress

- *Marriage Preferences and Decision Rights among Nepali Youth* (with Ajinkya Keskar)

  Original survey of university students in Nepal, fielding winter 2026–27, combining attitude and decision-rights questions with hypothetical-choice vignettes over caste, education, earnings, work plans, and astrological compatibility. The design elicits both respondents' own preferences and expected parental approval, and recovers search parameters to calibrate a model of marriage search.

Seminar and Conference Presentations

- Hamilton College, Department of Economics Seminar, November 2026
- CREED Conference, October 2026
- Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting, November 2025
- WeRise Conference, October 2025
- Lake Economics Development Workshop, April 2025
- Southern Economic Association (SEA) Annual Meeting, November 2024

Conference Attendance

- Lake Economics Development Workshop, May 2026
- Teaching at a Teaching Intensive Institution, September 2024

Experience

Teaching Experience

Wake Forest University
Instructor
- Introduction to Economics (ECN 150), Fall 2026
- Econometrics (ECN 209), Spring 2027

Binghamton University
Instructor of Record
- The Economics of Poverty and Discrimination, Summer 2025
- Statistical Methods, Summer 2024

Teaching Assistant
- Math Analysis for Economists, Fall 2025
- Information Economics, Fall 2025
- Microeconomics of Development, Spring 2025, Spring 2026
- Data Analysis in Economics, Spring 2024, Fall 2024
- International Monetary Policy, Fall 2023
- Macroeconomic Theory, Spring 2023

- Microeconomic Theory, Fall 2022
- Principles of Microeconomics, Fall 2021, Spring 2022

Teacher Training
- New Faculty Learning Community, Center for the Advancement of Teaching, Wake Forest University, 2026–27
- Wicked Graduate Teaching Workshop, Binghamton University, Fall 2024
- Scholarly Teaching, Binghamton University, Fall 2023
- Harpur Program on Online Teaching Pedagogy, Binghamton University, Spring 2023

Private Sector Experience

Objecutive, Inc. **Fort Lee, NJ**
Financial Specialist *May 2019–Jul 2021*
- Integrated new asset classes into the company's portfolio management system and helped developers understand the operation of unique instrument types.
- Assisted clients from both a user-interface and a database perspective (SQL) in their use of the system.
- Managed teams of up to four specialists to troubleshoot and analyze system problems and resolve system discrepancies.

Service

2026: Referee, *Economics of Education Review*

2022–2024: Co-President, Economics Graduate Student Organization, Binghamton University

2022–2023: Graduate Student Advisory Committee, Binghamton University

Skills

Languages: Nepali (native), English (native/bilingual), Hindi (proficient)

Software: Stata, R, Python, SQL, LaTeX, EViews

References

Ajinkya Keskar
Department of Economics
Binghamton University
akeskar@binghamton.edu

Erik Nesson
Department of Economics
Wake Forest University
nessonet@wfu.edu

David Slichter
Department of Economics
Binghamton University
slichter@binghamton.edu

Last updated: *October 18, 2026.*